

**What else to watch:** *Singin' in the Rain* (1952, pp.122–25) ■ *From Here to Eternity* (1953) ■ *Gigi* (1958) ■ *West Side Story* (1961, p.334) ■ *The Haunting* (1963) ■ *Mary Poppins* (1964) ■ *Cabaret* (1972) ■ *Les Misérables* (2012)

**Captain von Trapp** is bemused to find his seven children dripping wet and dressed in loose-fitting clothes made by their governess, Maria, out of the floral drapery in her room.

the situation she has created, Maria flees back to the abbey, but the abbess encourages her to return to her new home. To the children's delight, the captain marries her, and the movie might have ended happily there. Instead, however, it continues in a markedly different tone, its focus shifting from the family's domestic situation to its place in the wider world. As the Nazi *Anschluss* of Austria threatens to sweep away all they cherish, their fate becomes linked with that of the country.

The danger is most poignantly represented by Rolfe (Daniel Truhitte), a local boy who is in love with von Trapp's eldest daughter Liesl (Charmian Carr). Rolfe's arrival one day in a Nazi uniform shocks both the family and the audience, and serves to demonstrate the way in which innocent youth can be corrupted and turned to malign ends. The captain tells him, "They don't own you," revealing his fear of what is happening to the country and its people, and reminding Rolfe that he has free will. But Rolfe nevertheless betrays the family.

### Songs of comfort

Much of the singing in *The Sound of Music* is about finding joy in the ordinary and the commonplace, but



in several instances the songs are used to overcome fear or to ward off danger. *My Favorite Things* is sung when Maria tries to calm the children during a violent storm, and in the final set piece, when the family performs on stage at a festival in Salzburg, they are singing to buy time as danger closes in around them. While Nazi officers watch from the front row, there are soldiers waiting in the wings to prevent the family's escape and to force Captain von Trapp into military service the moment the show is over.

The movie's overwhelming optimism does not simply derive from the hills being "alive with the sound of music" (in the words of the titular song), but from its message that honesty and goodness are defenses against evil. When Captain von Trapp rouses the festival audience to sing *Edelweiss*, a tender song about the Alpine flower that symbolizes Austria, he is affirming his loyalty to a country that has been annexed by a ruthless foreign power, and standing up in defense of everything that he sees as decent and good.

In a sense, then, Maria and the captain are protecting not only their children, but a whole way of life, and their final escape over the mountains carries the hope that this way of life will survive. ■

**“When the Lord closes a door,  
somewhere He opens a window.”**

**Maria / The Sound of Music**